

James: A Faith That Works

The brother of Jesus refuses to let you believe without becoming.

Text. James 1 to 5

Good for. A church comfortable with right belief and slow obedience

The arc. James writes to scattered believers and tests their faith at every seam where life applies pressure. The single thread is that a faith which never reaches the hands, the tongue, or the wallet was never living faith at all.

1. Count It All Joy

James 1:1-18

Big idea. Trials are not the enemy of faith but its proving ground, and the God who gives wisdom never tempts us toward evil.

Aim. To reframe the hearer's hard season as the place faith is made real.

Notes

2. Doers, Not Hearers

James 1:19-27

Big idea. The word that only enters the ear deceives, while the word that reaches the hands becomes religion God accepts.

Aim. To convict the hearer who mistakes listening for obeying.

Notes

3. No Partiality in the Pew

James 2:1-13

Big idea. Showing favor to the rich and shame to the poor denies the gospel that chose the poor to be rich in faith.

Aim. To expose the hidden ways a church honors the wrong things.

Notes

4. Faith Without Works Is Dead

James 2:14-26

Big idea. A faith that feeds no one and changes nothing is a corpse, because living faith always shows itself in works.

Aim. To settle whether the hearer's faith has a pulse.

Notes

5. The Tongue and the Two Wisdoms

James 3:1-18

Big idea. The small tongue sets the whole life on fire, and the wisdom from above is known by its peace, not its cleverness.

Aim. To make the hearer hear their own speech as the test of their heart.

Notes

6. Friendship With the World

James 4:1-17

Big idea. Quarrels come from desires at war within, and the cure is to humble ourselves before the God who gives grace to the lowly.

Aim. To name the cravings underneath the conflicts in the hearer's life.

Notes

7. Patience, Prayer, and the Wandering

James 5:1-20

Big idea. The rich who hoard are warned, the suffering are told to wait for the Lord, and the church is called to pray and to bring back the one who strays.

Aim. To send the hearer out as someone who waits in faith and goes after the lost.

Notes

HOW TO USE THIS SERIES

These are starting points, not scripts. Each series gives you the arc, the divisions, and a working aim for every sermon, but the breakdown here is scaffolding you will take down once the text has done its own work in you. Read the whole book before you preach the first week of it. Let the passage divisions teach you where the seams actually are.

The text sets the agenda. Not the felt needs you arrived with, not the outline that looks clean on a slide, not the application you already know you want to land. Sit under the passage long enough for it to surprise you, and then preach what it says rather than what you planned. A big idea you did not have to fight for is usually one the text did not give you.